

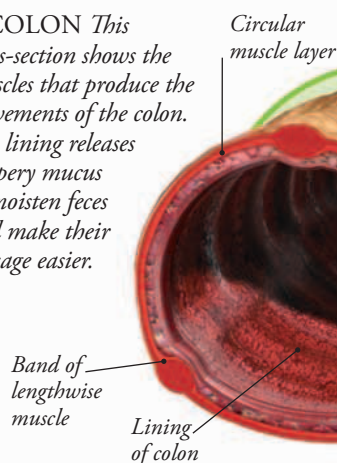
End of the line

The final section of the digestive tract, the large intestine, is twice the width of the small intestine but only one quarter of its length. The large intestine receives watery, indigestible waste from your small intestine. Here, it absorbs valuable water from that waste, forming semisolid feces (poo) that are pushed out of your body.

THE BOWELS OF THE BODY

The large intestine has three parts—the cecum, the colon, and the rectum. The longest section, the colon, forms and moves feces, which contain waste food, dead cells, and bacteria. They eventually arrive in the rectum and are expelled when you feel an urge to go to the bathroom.

► **COLON** *This cross-section shows the muscles that produce the movements of the colon. The lining releases slippery mucus to moisten feces and make their passage easier.*



The cecum is the first part of the large intestine.

The ascending colon rises up the right side of the abdomen.

One of three bands of muscle that run along the length of the colon.

The transverse colon passes across the abdomen, just below the stomach.

A valve stops waste from flowing back into the small intestine.

Feces inside the S-shaped sigmoid colon.

The appendix sticks out from the cecum.

Rectum

The digestive process also produces waste gases, which are expelled through the anus. Flatulence, or "passing gas" as it is known politely, can be noisy and smelly!

Anus

LOOK CLOSER: FRIENDLY BACTERIA

Your colon contains trillions of bacteria, many of which are friendly or helpful to the body. They digest material that human enzymes cannot, releasing useful nutrients, such as vitamin K, which the body absorbs.

► COLON BACTERIA

The lining of the colon (brown) is covered by bacteria (purple) that feed on undigested food.

